

a problem: its hands-free microphone picks up too much ambient sound, and it seems it doesn't filter noise.



Sony Ericsson Walkman W710i
A sporty mobile

Speed

The Nokia 3250 takes very long to boot—23 seconds to be precise, though this is not, of course, a major irritant. The SEs boot the fastest, in as little as 5 seconds. The user interface of the Nokia 5300 is amazingly fast; that of the Nokia 3250 is slow, probably because of its ageing processor. The SEs have their tried and tested interface, which is pretty fast, too.

Imaging Quality

No prizes for guessing this one: the SE CyberShot K550i has the best photo quality. This can be attributed to its auto-focus and protected lens (meaning fewer scratches) in addition to better optics.

In video mode, the Nokia 3250 exhibited better quality, though it slowed

down significantly every time the zoom level was changed.

TALK AND CLICK

The phones in this category are not too expensive, and at the same time, they come with many of the features of their more expensive brethren, such as a camera and multimedia capabilities. These present the best of both worlds.

For this test, we decided to test some new entrants into the mobile market. We left out some of the more popular brands—those generally perceived as the best—and we'd like to see if these newer players can beat what we've seen earlier on the more popular brands!

The phones we reviewed that fell in this group were the E61 and CL71 from BenQ-Siemens, the bleu 550X, 551X, 651X and 651Z, and the Intex AURA i1224 Black.

Features

Design And Ergonomics

The BenQ-Siemens CL71 and the bleu 651Z are the only slider phones and are the most stylish. The slider makes them look smaller because the keypad gets pulled in, but these are, in general, thicker and not easy to carry in a pocket. The rest of the phones were candybars; of these, the Intex AURA i1224 Black

was the sleekest and thinnest. The bleu 551X was the lightest phone at 71.4 grams.

The BenQ-Siemens held the edge with better build quality, while the user interfaces of all the phones were equally easy to use. The keypad of the BenQ-Siemens CL71 was a little difficult to use because, they are caved in to accommodate the slider mechanism. All the bleu phones have a plastic body with a glossy piano-black finish.

Basic Features

Barring the BenQ-Siemens E61, bleu 550X and 551X, which had a 128 x 160 display with 65 K colours, all the rest had a display resolution of 176 x 220 with 256 K colours. The BenQ-Siemens CL71 can store up to 1,000 numbers in its phone book, while the E61, bleu 651Z and the Intex, which were next-best, can each store 500.

Frequent SMS-ers will love the predictive text feature which is featured on all these phones. This feature allows you type in your SMS in a fewer number of key-presses by predicting the word as you type, using an inbuilt dictionary.

The BenQ-Siemens and Intex phones support Themes that let you alter the looks of the display interface. All these phones have MP3 ringtone support.

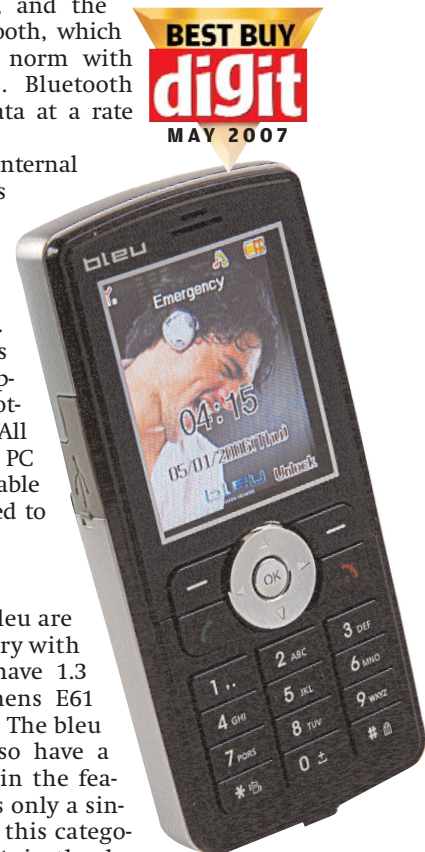
Java applications are supported on all the phones, and you can either connect to the mobile Internet to download and install these (all the phones support this too), or use Bluetooth, IR, or USB, as applicable. The BenQ-Siemens CL71, bleu 551X, and the Intex AURA support Bluetooth, which is already a connectivity norm with most phones these days. Bluetooth allows you to exchange data at a rate faster than infrared.

In addition to having internal memories, all the phones supported memory expandability. The BenQ-Siemens E61 and bleu 651X support miniSD, while the rest support microSD. Except for the BenQ-Siemens E61 and bleu 550X, all supported the convenient hot-swappability of memory. All the phones connected to a PC and showed up as removable USB drives without the need to install any drivers.

The Camera

The 651X and 651Z from bleu are the only two in this category with 2-MP cameras. The rest have 1.3 MP, while the BenQ-Siemens E61 comes with a VGA camera. The bleu 550X, 651X, and 651Z also have a flash. This is interesting: in the feature-rich category, there is only a single phone with a flash. In this category, the BenQ-Siemens E61 is the lone phone without support for video capture.

The phones in the "Talk and Click" category are not too expensive, and present the best of both worlds



bleu 651X
A phone or a webcam?

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